‘I can’t imagine myself doing anything else’

ARIA, a twentysomething singer from Kerala, on her life in a Korean pop band and how fame and scrutiny have driven her to make better music



IN 2021, Aria was Gauthami, a dorky teenager on a year-long break from studies. Then she decided to audition online to be a K-Pop idol. “When I first introduced my dream to my family over dinner, everybody laughed and felt it was one of my crazy obsessions,” she says. Today, she's a member of the girl group X:IN and only the second such idol from India. After two years in Seoul, she's leaner, speaks English with an accent, has blonde hair and, for some, looks fairer. For her, though, that's just the process of growing up. Says Aria, “Being an idol comes with a lot of downsides, but I love what I'm doing. I cannot imagine myself doing anything else.”

> “YOU NEED DETERMINATION TO BE A K-POP IDOL. THEY CAN ELIMINATE YOU FROM THE COMPANY. YOUR SURVIVAL INSTINCT MUST BE STRONG”

Q. How did your interest in being a K-Pop idol begin?
I became a K-Pop fan around 2017 after listening to BTS. I was mesmerised. Then I got into more K-Pop groups—they have their own charisma so I was like, what would it be like if I was part of such a group? It was just a fleeting thought. I tried for online auditions. I remember filming my dance audition to a remix version of Blackpink's ‘How You Like That’. I also sent a rapping and singing video. Fortunately, I got in and here I am in Korea.

FMCG brands are spicing up their offerings with Korean flavours. ITC’s YiPPee!, HUL’s Knorr, Nestle’s Maggi and CG Foods’s Wai Wai have all launched Korean-flavoured noodles. “Today, 70 per cent of the growth in the instant noodles category is coming from Korean flavours,” admits Varun Chaudhary, CEO of the CG Group. This year, the company plans to expand its Dynamite range of Korean-flavoured noodles with two new flavours—*kimchi* and *gochugaru*—to the existing five. Last year, ITC teamed up with popular Korean singer Aoora to launch three Korean flavours of Bingo! chips and released the K-Pop number ‘Maeun Maeun’ (spicy in Korean), which has netted over 20.4 million users on YouTube and 45.7 million impressions on Instagram. Food delivery platform Swiggy has seen a 59 per cent growth in online orders for Korean food over the past three years, and not just in metros and tier-1 cities but also in places like Surat, Thiruvananthapuram, Vadodara, Mysore, Mangaluru, Nashik, Rajkot and Patna.

Korean restaurants are also experiencing a shift in their customer base. What began as niche dining spots for expat communities are now attracting mainstream diners. When Korean restaurant chain Kori’s first opened in 2012, its patrons were mostly Koreans, northeasterners or foreigners. But that changed after the pandemic. “Now, 80 per cent of our diners are north Indians,” says owner Lee Sang Hoon.